HEMANT MISHRA



Back in the 1920s, Burde Sadanand Kamath and his elder brother would visit Karnataka's Malnad region on horseback to source tobacco. Seeing that ornaments crafted in their coastal hometown were highly sought after by people in the hill tracts, Kamath ventured into the gold jewellery trade and set up Neo Jewellery Mart in Udupi in 1935.

However, the wartime Gold Control Rules prohibiting gold ornaments of more than 14 carat purity led to Kamath exiting the business in the early '60s. His son Madhukar re-entered the business in 1979 with a showroom in Udupi under the brand name Abharan.

Madhukar's elder son Subhas, in Class 9 then, recalls: "From Day 1, my brother and I had to spend a couple of hours in the store." By 1987, with college degrees in hand, both Subhas and brother Mahesh formally entered the family business. They opened a second store in Shivamogga in 1991 and a third one in Mangaluru in 2007. Abharan was among the first brands to import a gold testing machine to check for purity, says Subhas.

The brand now has 14 stores in small towns like Padubidri, Karkala, Belthangady, Brahmavara, Kundapura, Byndoor, Hebri, Thirthahalli, Sagar and Chikmagalur, and one in Panjim in Goa.

Both Subhas and his father Madhukar, now 82, share a love of automobiles. Kamath Sr has handed down his prize possessions—a 1979 Honda XL 250S Enduro motorcycle and a Yamaha Virago 535—to Subhas. Kamath Jr goes on regular off-roading biking trips in the Himalayas; lately, he has been making these trips in his Jeep Wrangler. "I love water sports too. Since we are by the sea, I bought myself a jet ski," he says. Subas also owns a kayak and a 33 ft boat that he takes out for his other love—angling.

-Ajay Sukumaran

opportunities and offering sops to specific businesses, including creating industrial areas and better infrastructure support. Telangana, for instance, is looking beyond Hyderabad for growth. IT nodes have come up in Karimnagar and Warangal and it is expanding incubation facilities for entrepreneurs to Tier II towns. The Madhya Pradesh Investment Promotion Policy, 2014, has provision for 'geographical multiple' in which proposals for investments in remote areas attract additional benefits. Moreover, investments in relatively backward areas are eligible for cash subsidies ranging from 10-40 per cent.

The thread that binds all these individuals, though, is foresight and perseverance. Many have reinvented themselves after having lost it all. Ask Rajat Agrawal of Jaipur, who has sunk to the very bottom several times, only to resurface on top—wiser, and richer. Some of them like to enjoy their wealth, moving from humble Ambassadors and Fiats to Mercedes SUVs, a chopper or a speedboat, palatial houses and designer wear. Others choose to live less flamboyant lives, pumping back profits into their businesses or paying off their liabilities to keep their companies debt-light. Most of them engage in philanthropy, often supporting education and health initiatives in their home towns.

The growth of the small town can only be a welcome trend. Especially as big cities get saturated and their infrastructure turns creaky. "Focusing on growth only in large cities leads to challenges for a growing country like ours," says Gandhi. You only have to witness the deteriorating quality of life in the cities, plagued by air and noise pollution, and the exponential growth in vehicles that have clogged our roads. As per the World Air Quality report by IQAir in 2021, India was home to 11 of the 15 most polluted cities in central and south Asia. "Thus, mak-